

In a Jam

Loud war cries may have spotlighted other tussles, but they couldn't drown Rahul Dravid's quiet, almost anguished, battle with his own demons. Unable to bear media scrutiny and, worse, criticism, he relinquished captaincy only to find himself confronting a tougher enemy: himself. Pressure for place from more in-form teammates, as well as from his own high standards, is wreaking havoc in the former skipper's mind.



"We have got support from the public in India and abroad. If some people see problems with the ICL, I do not know what is their reason."

SUBHASH CHANDRA PROMOTER OF ICL

"I can't see any threat

from the ICL. Not many people are interested in watching retired players in action. I see no reason for young players going there."



SHARAD PAWAR PRESIDENT, BCCI

Chappell's resignation amid speculation of strife between him and the players. This dispute was fuelled by public statements made by an uncharacteristically vocal Sachin Tendulkar, who said he was "hurt" by Chappell's allegations that the seniors had attitude problems.

If it wasn't Chappell, then it was BCCI locking horns with the players. As a quasi-punishment for failure in the World Cup, the working committee decided to withdraw the graded contract system, where players were paid a lump sum per year. Instead, it mooted a less generous match fee format, where the bonuses would be significant but performance-linked. Post T20 victory, the balance of power shifted to the players again. The contract system was back, this time with four grades and a pool of 33 players as opposed to three grades and fewer players in its earlier avatar.

Later in the year, money became the bone of contention again, this time the chief national selector Dilip Vengsarkar expressing discontent at being asked to discontinue his columns. The dispute began when a gag was ordered after Vengsarkar and team manager Lalchand Rajput

said a word too many to the media. Despite orders to the contrary, Vengsarkar gave an interview and wrote his column, ironically, for a newspaper owned by BCCI President Sharad Pawar's brother. When demands that he be compensated for the losses he would suffer due to this embargo were not met, Vengsarkar threatened to resign. Much across-the-table negotiations and sops like trips to Australia later, temporary peace was ensured.

The personality-driven tussles spilled over on to the cricket field too, with jibes, jostles and jelly beans taking centre stage. What began with Sreesanth's bat-swinging episode in December 2006, continued with Zaheer Khan waving his willow at Kevin Pietersen over coloured jujubes, and only escalated against the Australians during their ODI series in India. Sreesanth was the unofficial face of Indian chin-thrusting and fist-pumping, but monkey chants against Andrew Symonds became the official noise. The bonhomie surrounding the traditionally hard-nosed India-Pakistan series seemed almost banal in comparison, underlining that the battleground has changed. It's moved to Down Under. ■